MODULE 00 · AMBITIOUS ENTREPRENEURSHIP

No-Bullshit Entrepreneurship

What kills startups, and what will this course demand from you?

COURSE PATH

00 01 02 03 04 05 06 07 08 09 10 11 12

COURSE MATERIAL · SCAN NOW

All slides live on GitHub

The newest version, free, no account needed

github.com/BaNburger/
AmbitiousEntrepreneurship

1. **Open the link**
   github.com/BaNburger/AmbitiousEntrepreneurship
2. **Go to modules**
   then 00-kickoff
3. **Click the lecture PDF**
   M00_Lecture_No-Bullshit-Entrepreneurship.pdf, download top right

Public course repository of Ambitious Entrepreneurship. The QR code opens github.com/BaNburger/AmbitiousEntrepreneurship.

WHERE WE ARE · THE COURSE

Session one of thirteen

From first idea to first revenue. Where teams get to:

A problem worth fixing, with names
Problem space (M03)

An MVP people use without help
Prototyping (M06)

First customers who are strangers
First users (M08)



BASTIAN The course path of Ambitious Entrepreneurship, sessions 00 to 12. Goals from the module guides.

CHECK-IN · SLIDO OR HANDS

How big could your startup get?

1. A good side income
2. A solid company of 50 people
3. A unicorn
4. The next Google

Aim it: why now, and why you

The companies founded now will shape the next 50 years, so why not yours?

01 Aim it: why now, and why you
02 Ground it: start from a problem
03 Test it: one loop a week
04 How this course works
05 Wrap-up and check-out
06 Workshop: autopsy your startup before it dies

INPUT 1 OF 3 · AIM IT · THREE QUESTIONS

Why you, and why now?

1

Why is now a good time to start?

2

Do you need to be special to found?

3

How big should you aim?

WHY NOW, WHY YOU

The companies founded now will shape how we see the world for the next

50 years

The best time to start in decades.

Maybe in 50 years.

WHY NOW · EVERY TRANSITION

At every transition, a new giant appeared

Not every old giant fell. The next seat is still open

OLYMPIA → IBM

IBM → Microsoft

Microsoft → Google

Google → OpenAI

OpenAI → ? your startup

WHERE THE PUCK IS GOING

Nobody knows where the puck is going. Whoever finds out fastest builds the next big thing.

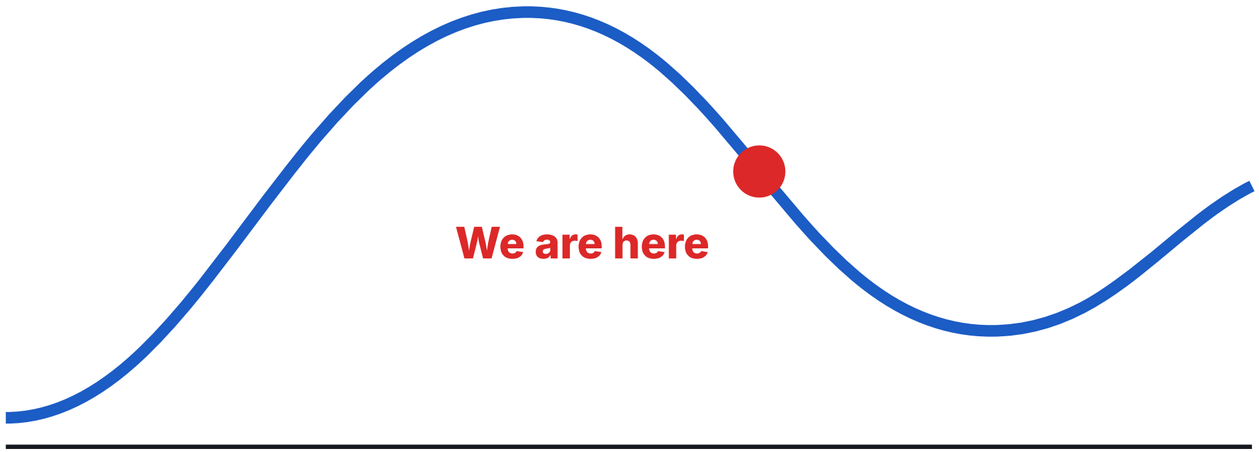
It could be you

BASTIAN After Wayne Gretzky, passing on his father Walter's advice to skate "to where the puck is going" (Gretzky & Reilly, 1990). Bastian's twist (2026-10-19).

WHY NOW · DALIO'S BIG CYCLE, MY READ

Dalio sees a turn coming. I see an opening

Ray Dalio puts us late in a cycle of about 75 years, just before the breakdown



about 75 years, give or take 30 (Dalio)

My read for founders

A productivity crisis exposes slow incumbents

Capital exists, but it flows to few. Earn it with evidence

Climate, security and demography need new solutions

FRAMEWORK Dalio, R. (2025). How Countries Go Broke: The Big Cycle. Avid Reader Press. Dalio (2026, March 14), Fortune: "We are now in a new Stage 5". The read for founders is Bastian's.

WHY YOU

They weren't better prepared than you

Age and education when they started

19 **Bill Gates**

Harvard, left without a degree · Microsoft 1975

21 **Steve Jobs**

One semester at Reed College · Apple 1976

25 **Larry Page & Sergey Brin**

Stanford PhD students, never finished · Google 1998

28 **Hasso Plattner**

Engineer, left IBM with four colleagues · SAP 1972

30 **Jensen Huang**

Chip designer, master's from night classes · Nvidia 1993

30 **Werner von Siemens**

Artillery school, no university · Siemens 1847

DATA Ages from birth and founding dates, education at founding. Wikipedia, retrieved 2026-10-19.

BUT…

~~But I'm not an engineer...~~

Yes, you can build it!

~~But we don't have a GmbH...~~

Yes, you can ship it!

~~But we don't have a patent...~~

Customers don't buy patents!

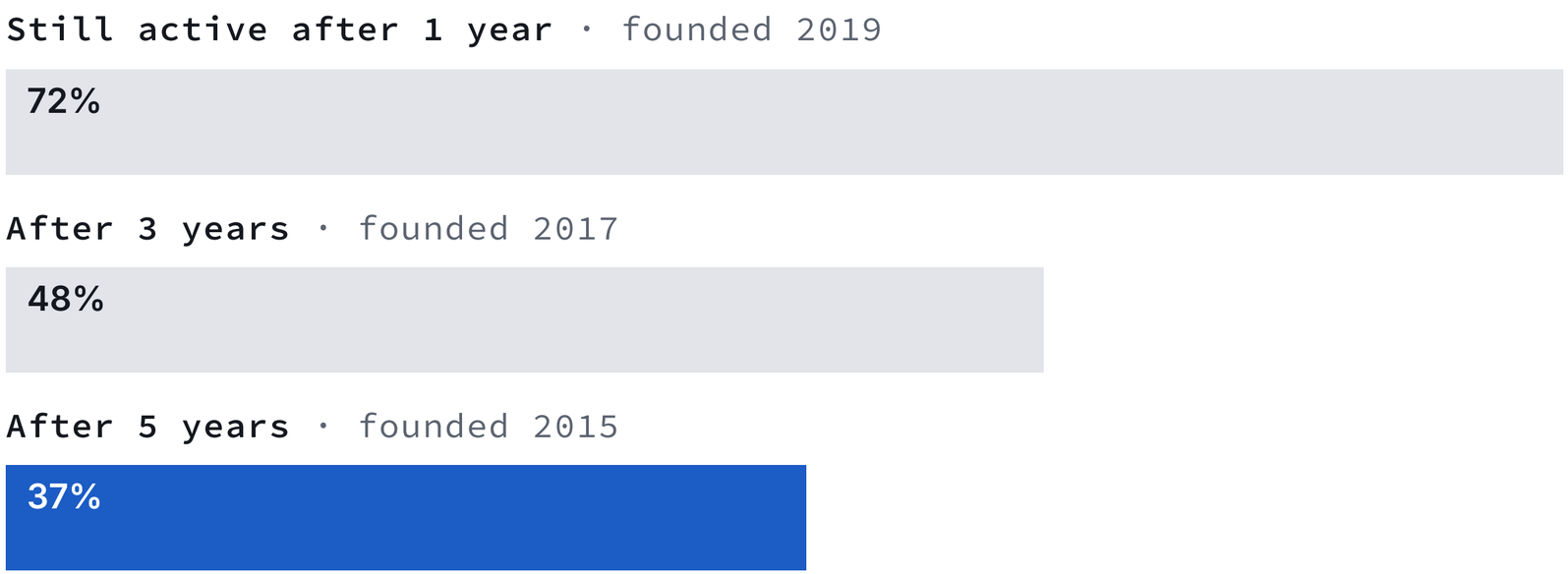
~~But we didn't get a grant...~~

Customers can pay you!

THE BASE RATE

Most new businesses* don't reach year five

Germany, share still active by year founded



* Not all new businesses are startups.

DATA Eurostat, business demography (bd_9bd_sz_cl_r2), Germany, survival rates for reference year 2020, industry, construction and services. Bars to scale.

BE AMBITIOUS

A big idea fails about as often as a small one. So aim for the next Google

Aim big. Start narrow.

Facebook began at one campus.

BASTIAN Bastian's view (2026-10-19). Failure rates after Kerr, Nanda & Rhodes-Kropf (2014), backup slide 89. Facebook opened to Harvard students only in February 2004. "Start narrow" after Graham (2012), How to Get Startup Ideas.

A TIER LIST OF STARTUP IDEAS

Aim for S. Stay out of the tarpit

Tarpit ideas look easy and die quietly

S Moonshots	The next Google · Industrial capabilities in space
A Unsexy plumbing	Compliance paperwork for small factories · AI-native compliance infrastructure
B Crowded trades	Yet another AI note-taker
C Wrapper zone	Chat with your files · Copilot for dog walkers
D Tarpit ideas	Restaurant & event discovery · An app to plan hangouts with friends · Trading tools for day traders
F	Fridge inventory app · A social network for pet owners · Investing your friends' money on Reddit tips

BASTIAN Bastian's tier list. Tarpits, copilots and the Reddit fund after Caldwell and Seibel's YC tarpit videos, the pet network after Graham (2012), space and compliance from YC's Requests for Startups (2026).

NOW YOU · ALONE · 2 MINUTES

Where does your idea land?

! YOUR STARTING POINT

Place it on the tier list

No idea yet? Take a frustration you saw someone fight last month.

→ Write your idea, problem or technology in one line
→ Which tier? Be honest
→ Write the one belief about customers it rests on
→ Like: "Junior HR managers would pay to stop candidates ghosting them"

Output One line, one tier, one belief

Minutes 2

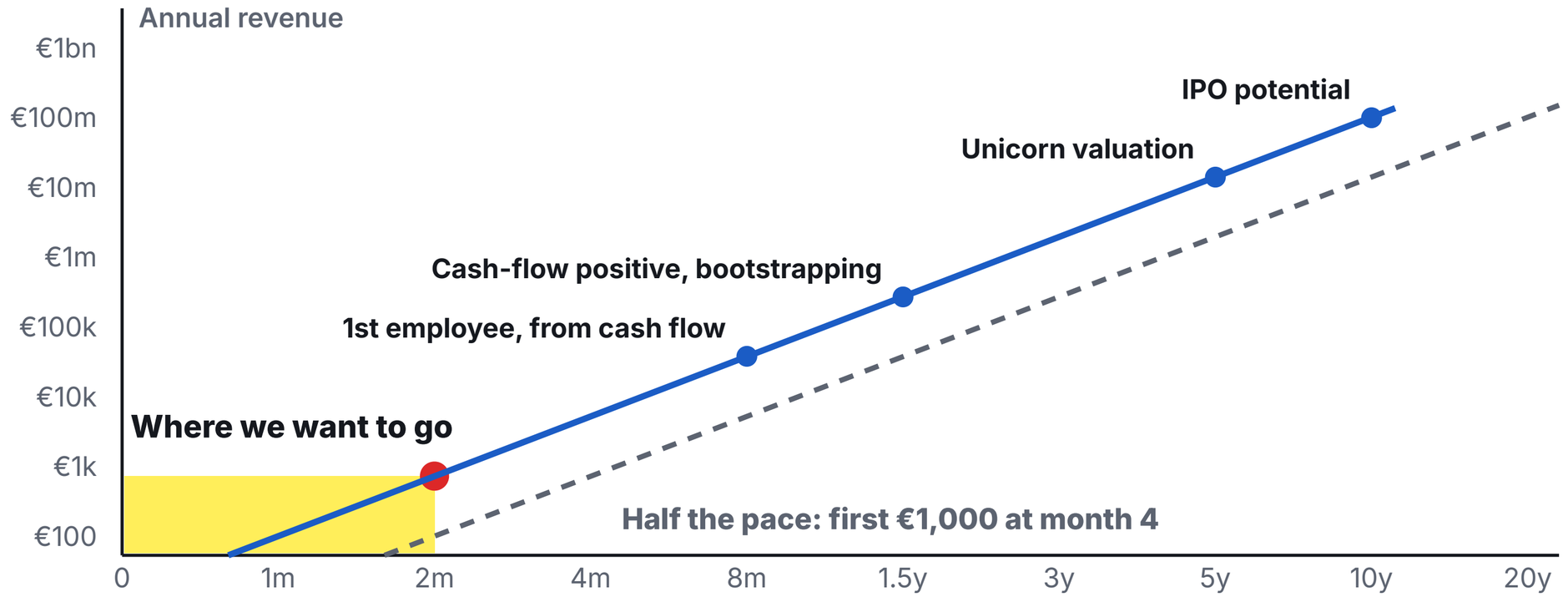
2:00

ILLUSTRATIVE Example belief ("Junior HR managers", not "companies").

REALITY CHECK · THE LONG GAME

Your first €1,000 sets the pace

Revenue and time on log scales. Half the pace now means half the pace later



BASTIAN Course material, "not a scientific chart". One straight line on log axes through €1,000 at month two, milestones on the line (2026-10-19).

INPUT 1 OF 3 · AIM IT · THE ANSWERS

Aim it: aim big, start narrow

1

Why is now a good time to start?

At every transition a new giant appeared. The next seat is still open

2

Do you need to be special to found?

No. They weren't better prepared than you, and you can build and ship it

3

How big should you aim?

Big. A big idea fails about as often as a small one. Start narrow

INPUT 2 OF 3 · CHAPTER 2 OF 6

Ground it: start from a problem

Every tool made building easier, but finding what people pay for never got easier.

01 ~~Aim it: why now, and why you~~

02 **Ground it: start from a problem**

03 **Test it: one loop a week**

04 How this course works

05 Wrap-up and check-out

06 Workshop: autopsy your startup before it dies

INPUT 2 OF 3 · GROUND IT · THREE QUESTIONS

What kills startups?

1

What kills most startups?

2

Which advice can wait?

3

Where should you start?

THE #1 KILLER · 101 POST-MORTEMS

"Tackling problems that are interesting to solve rather than those that serve a market need"

42% no market need

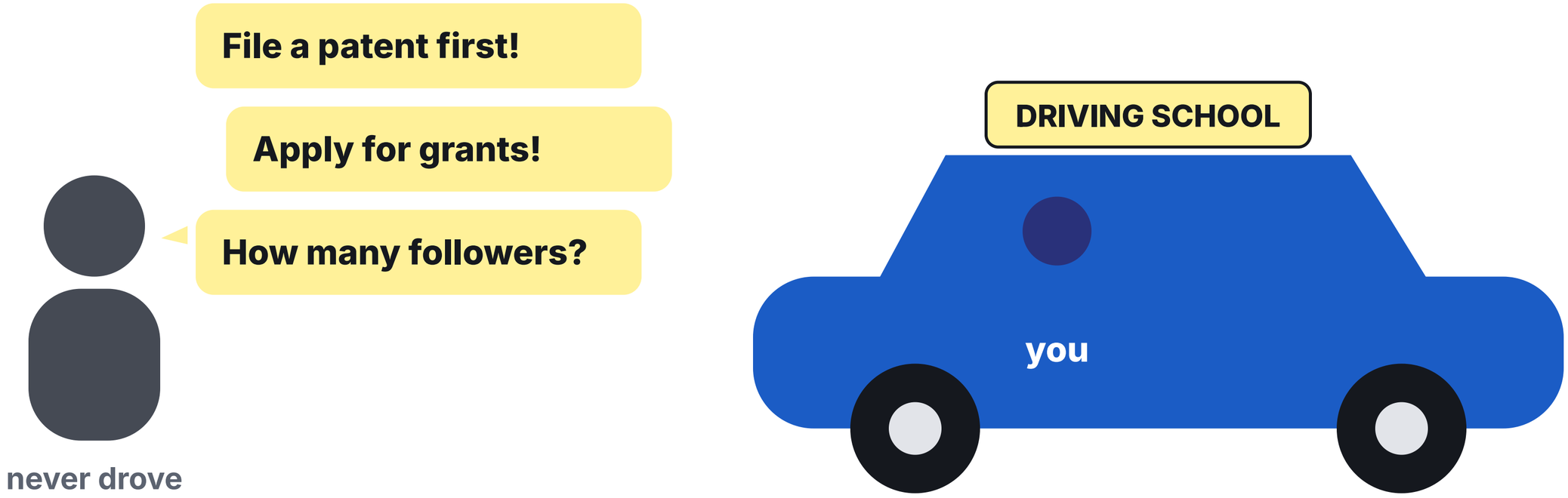
The #1 reason.

Not cash. Not competitors.

DATA CB Insights (2019). The top 20 reasons startups fail. 101 startup post-mortems.

WHO IS TALKING?

Driving lessons from someone who never drove?



BASTIAN Bastian's analogy, 2026-10-20. Michael Seibel (YC, 2024) says the same with "acting advice from someone who's not worked as an actor ...".

WHAT PEOPLE ASK YOU, AND WHAT MATTERS

YOU'LL BE ASKED

~~Do you have a patent?~~

~~Did you apply for grants?~~

~~How many followers?~~

~~How many downloads?~~

WHAT MATTERS

Who has the problem?

Who paid?

What did you learn since last time?

BASTIAN Bastian's view, 2026-10-20. The questions on the right are the course's weekly accountability questions.

> **Get a board of advisers. Partner with big companies. […] Get a patent strategy. […] And the product is like an afterthought.**

Michael Seibel, Y Combinator, on the advice founders get outside the Bay Area

YC Caldwell, D., & Seibel, M. (2024, August 6). The problem with startup "experts". Y Combinator, YouTube. Read in a transcript copy.

PATENTS

Patents matter in biotech. In software they come last

How 1,332 young tech companies ranked patents as protection

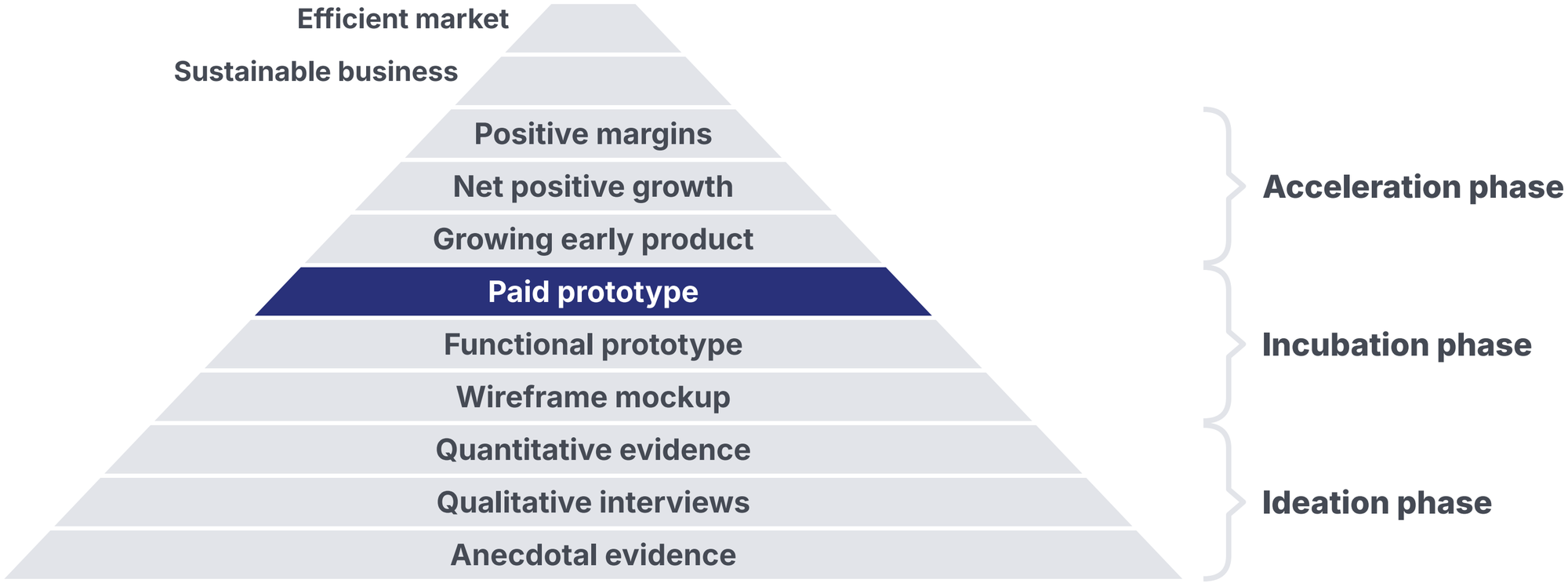


Either way, a patent doesn't tell you anyone wants the product

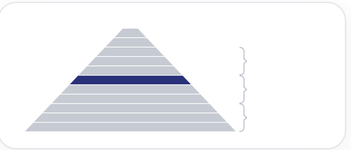
RESEARCH Graham, S., Merges, R., Samuelson, P., & Sichelman, T. (2009). High technology entrepreneurs and the patent system. Berkeley Technology Law Journal. *Venture-backed. Positions show rank, not distance.

GRANTS

A grant buys you time, not evidence



BASTIAN Bastian's view, 2026-10-20. EXIST pays up to €3,000 a month for a year (BMWi, 2021).



VANITY METRICS

Count what customers did, not what you collected

Validated learning is the only progress early on

COLLECTED

4,000 followers, 2 pitch awards, 1 patent filed, 40,000 page views

LEARNED

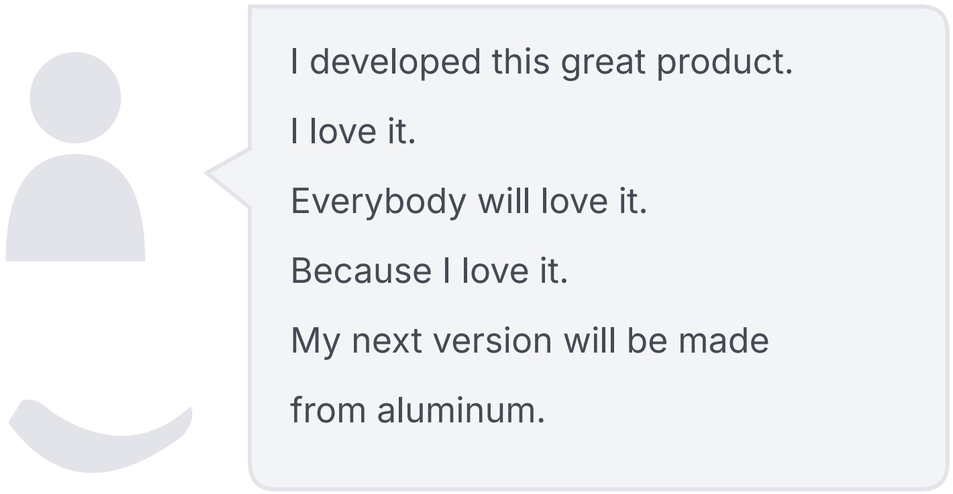
15 conversations, 3 next steps, 1 payment

> "... validated learning is backed up by empirical data collected from real customers." Eric Ries

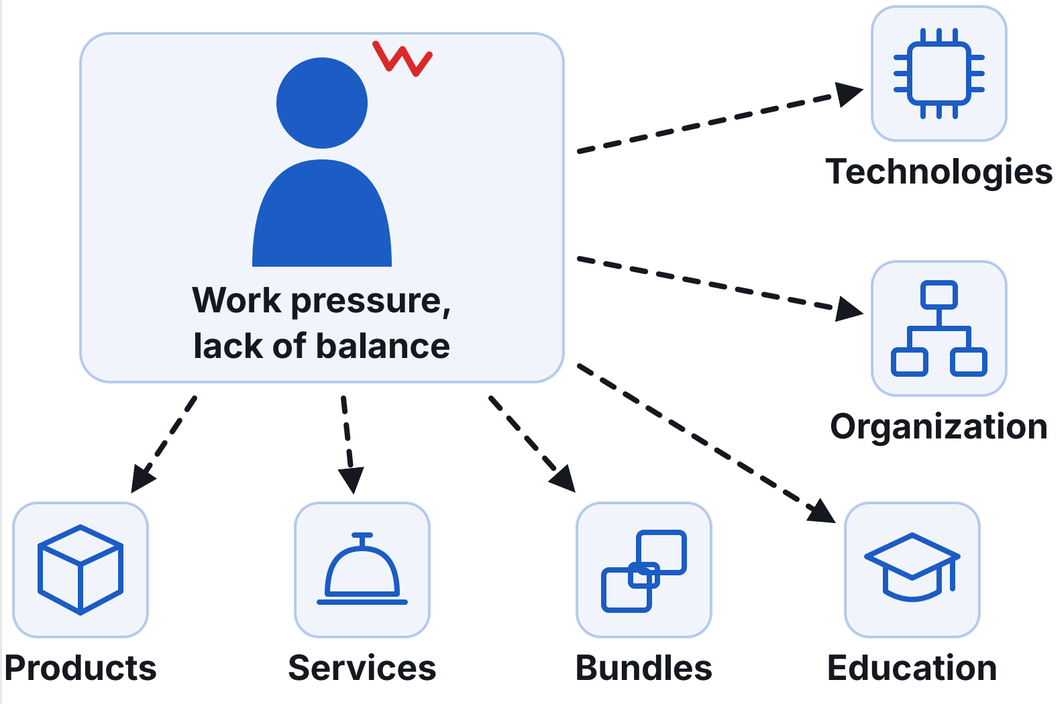
TECHNOLOGY PUSH

Start from a problem, not from your technology

Solution oriented



Problem oriented



NOW YOU · ALONE · 3 MINUTES

Sort the advice you got

! KEEP OR UNLEARN

Three pieces of advice, three questions

You keep only advice that makes you learn from customers.

→ **Write** the three pieces of startup advice you heard most this year
→ **Note** who gave each. Did they ever found a company?
→ **Ask** of each: does it make me learn from customers, or collect something?
→ **Mark** each one keep or unlearn
→ Like: "File a patent first", a bank adviser who never founded. Unlearn

Output Three lines, each marked keep or unlearn

Minutes 3

3:00

"NOW IT'S EASY"

Every new tool made building easier. None made startups easy

"It's getting so cheap to start a startup." Paul Graham, 2005



DATA Graham (2005), The Venture Capital Squeeze. Gruber (2005) on DHH's Rails screencast. AWS (2014) on the S3 launch, March 2006. Node.js about page (2012 archive). Bubble No-Code Census (2020). Karpathy (2025) on X. CB Insights (2026), poor product-market fit as root cause in 43% of the 385 shutdowns with known reasons (431 in all).

THE SKILL NEVER CHANGED

Tech changes. The founder's job doesn't

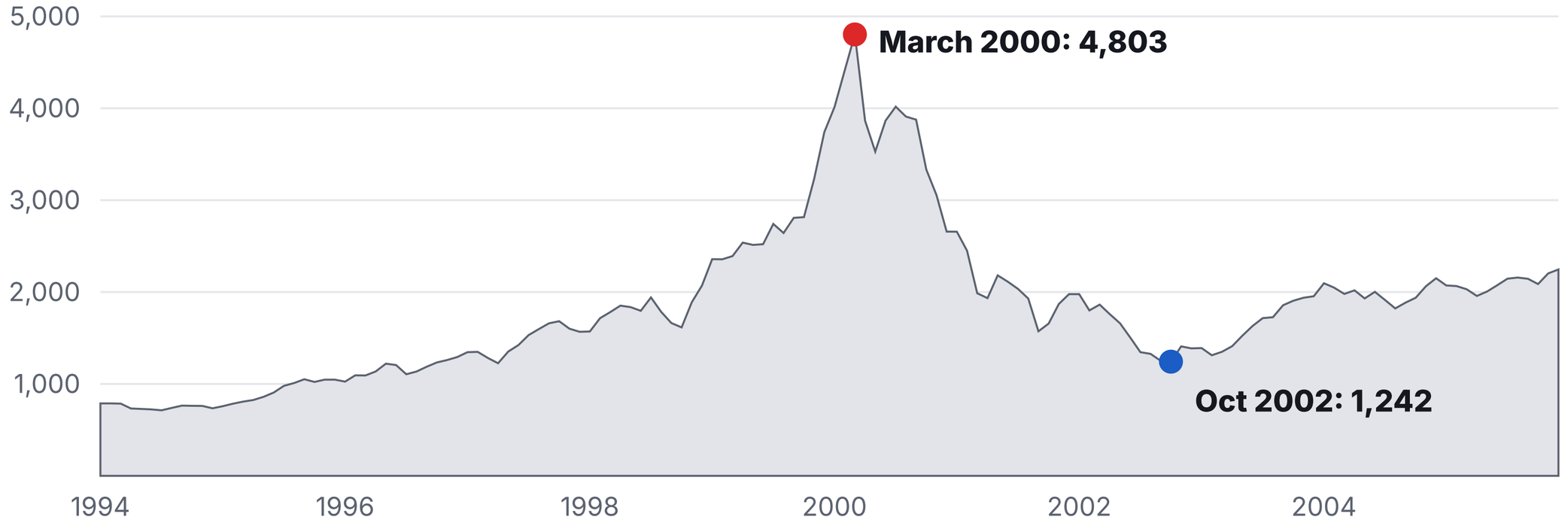
Every wave needed people who turned it into something others pay for



BASTIAN Bastian's framing (2026-10-19). Founding years from Wikipedia, retrieved 2026-10-19. Logos are trademarks of their owners.

BEFORE THE INTERNET

Startups happened before the internet, but they had a problem



DATA Nasdaq Composite index, monthly average of daily closes (NASDAQCOM), via FRED, Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis. Course material, redrawn without logos.

Mistakes aren't a necessary evil. They aren't evil at all. They are an inevitable consequence of doing something new.

Ed Catmull, co-founder of Pixar

BOOK

Creativity, Inc.

Ed Catmull with Amy Wallace, 2014

FRAMEWORK Catmull, E., & Wallace, A. (2014). *Creativity, Inc.* Random House, as quoted by Popova (2014), The Marginalian.

INPUT 2 OF 3 · GROUND IT · THE ANSWERS

Ground it: a problem first, the rest can wait

1

What kills most startups?

No market need, the #1 reason in 101 post-mortems

2

Which advice can wait?

Patents, grants, followers and downloads. Count what customers did

3

Where should you start?

From a problem people have, not from your technology

Test it: one loop a week

You beat the big ones by learning faster, with Build-Measure-Learn and the hierarchy of evidence.

01 ~~Aim it: why now, and why you~~
02 ~~Ground it: start from a problem~~
03 Test it: one loop a week
04 How this course works
05 Wrap-up and check-out
06 Workshop: autopsy your startup before it dies

INPUT 3 OF 3 · TEST IT · THREE QUESTIONS

How do you learn faster?

1

How can a small team beat a big one?

2

What is your idea, really?

3

How fast should you test?

THE CASH CONSTRAINT

Your startup is a loop. It runs

cash>0

```
while (cash > 0) {
  learn();
}
```

Every week without learning burns runway.

WORKING WITH CONSTRAINTS

While BMW runs one loop, you can run twenty

No manpower, no money, no time. Also no inertia, no legacy, no politics

BMW

people, money, time

1 iteration — legacy · politics · sign-offs

You

none of that, none of the drag

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20

BASTIAN Course material, Bastian's framing (2026-10-19). The 1 to 20 ratio is an illustration, not a measurement.

THE CORE OF THIS COURSE

Two ideas, two tools

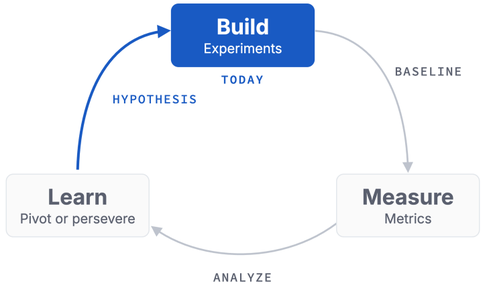
Everything in the next twelve weeks builds on these four

1 Speed matters

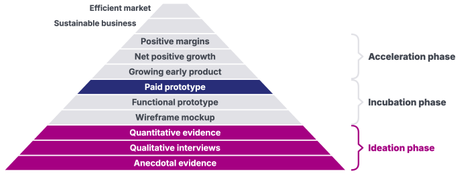
You beat the big ones only by learning faster

2 Validated learning beats opinions

Opinions are free. Evidence costs a conversation, a click, a payment



Build-Measure-Learn



Hierarchy of evidence

BASTIAN Bastian's course frame (2026-10-19). Build-Measure-Learn after Ries (2011), the hierarchy of evidence.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS · 4 RANDOMIZED TRIALS

Founders who test like scientists kill bad ideas sooner

759

startups in four randomized trials

+9.8

points more ideas terminated

+€7k

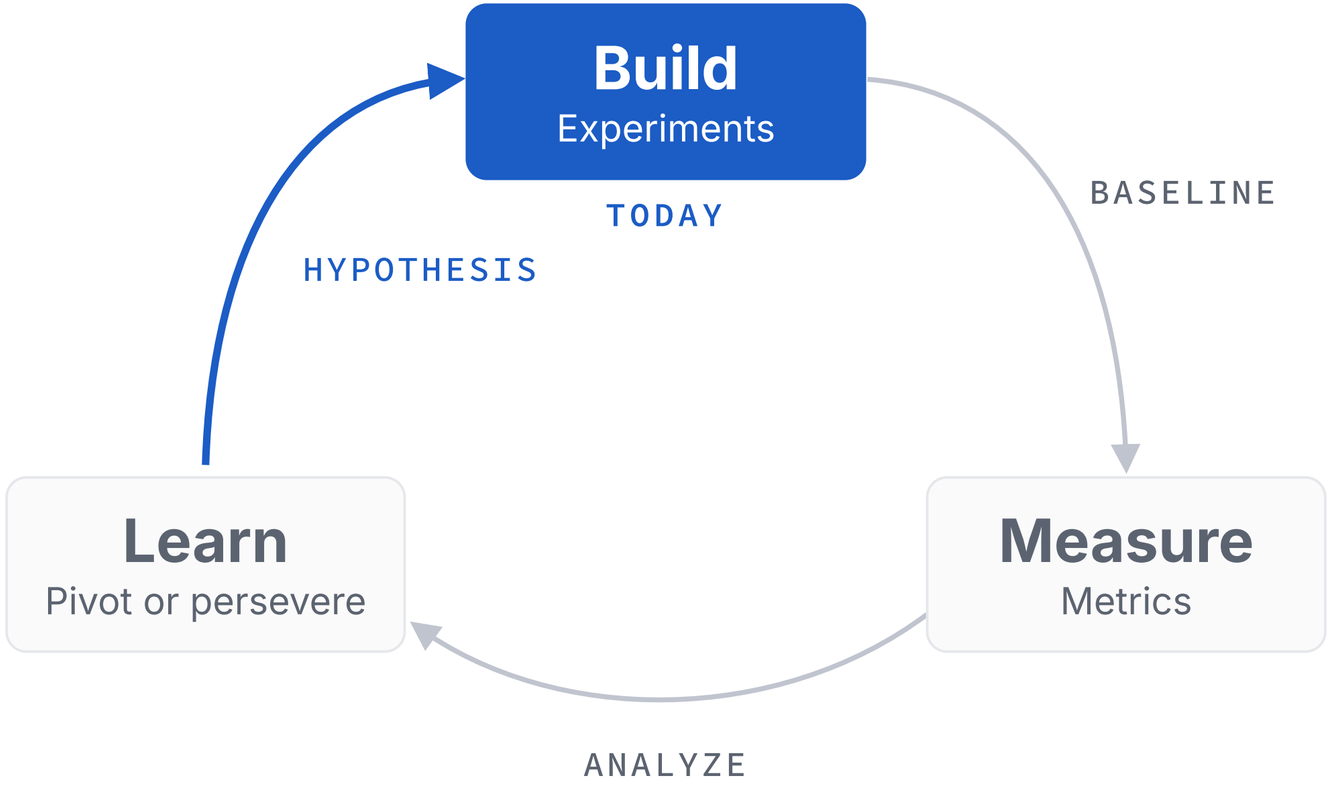
more revenue per firm over 16 months, many earned none

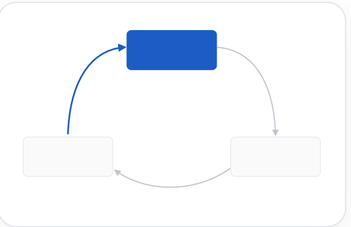
RESEARCH Camuffo et al. (2024), Strategic Management Journal, 759 firms. First trial: Camuffo et al. (2020), Management Science, 116 startups.

CORNERSTONE · BUILD-MEASURE-LEARN

Your idea is a **hypothesis**

Build the smallest test, measure, learn





THE PROBLEM HYPOTHESIS

Write hypotheses a stranger could prove wrong

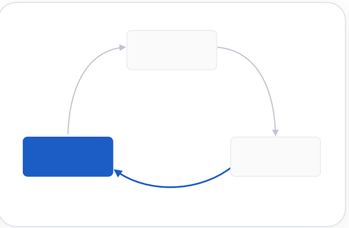
Who, problem, situation, workaround, cost

A SOLUTION IN DISGUISE

"People need an app that makes hiring easier."

A PROBLEM HYPOTHESIS

Junior HR managers struggle with candidates who ghost them after the interview. Today they chase by phone, which costs them [hours] a week.



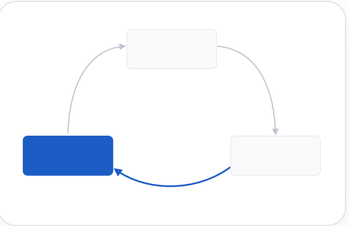
DISCIPLINED ENTREPRENEURSHIP · 24 STEPS

24 steps feel safe. It's still one loop

Each step is Build-Measure-Learn. Steps 20 and 21 meet reality

1 Market segmentation	**2** Select a beachhead market	**3** Build an end user profile	**4** TAM for the beachhead	**5** Persona for the beachhead	**6** Full life cycle use case
7 High-level product specification	**8** Quantify the value proposition	**9** Identify your next 10 customers	**10** Define your core	**11** Chart your competitive position	**12** Determine the customer organisation
13 Map how to acquire a paying customer	**14** TAM for follow-on markets	**15** Design a business model	**16** Set your pricing framework	**17** Calculate the unit economics	**18** Map the sales process
19 Calculate the customer economics	**20** Identify key assumptions	**21** Test key assumptions	**22** Define the MVP	**23** Prove your beachhead with your MVP	**24** Develop a product plan

FRAMEWORK Aulet, B. (2013). *Disciplined Entrepreneurship: 24 Steps to a Successful Startup*. Wiley. Step names, shortened.



REALITY CHECK

Every plan feels safe until reality hits back

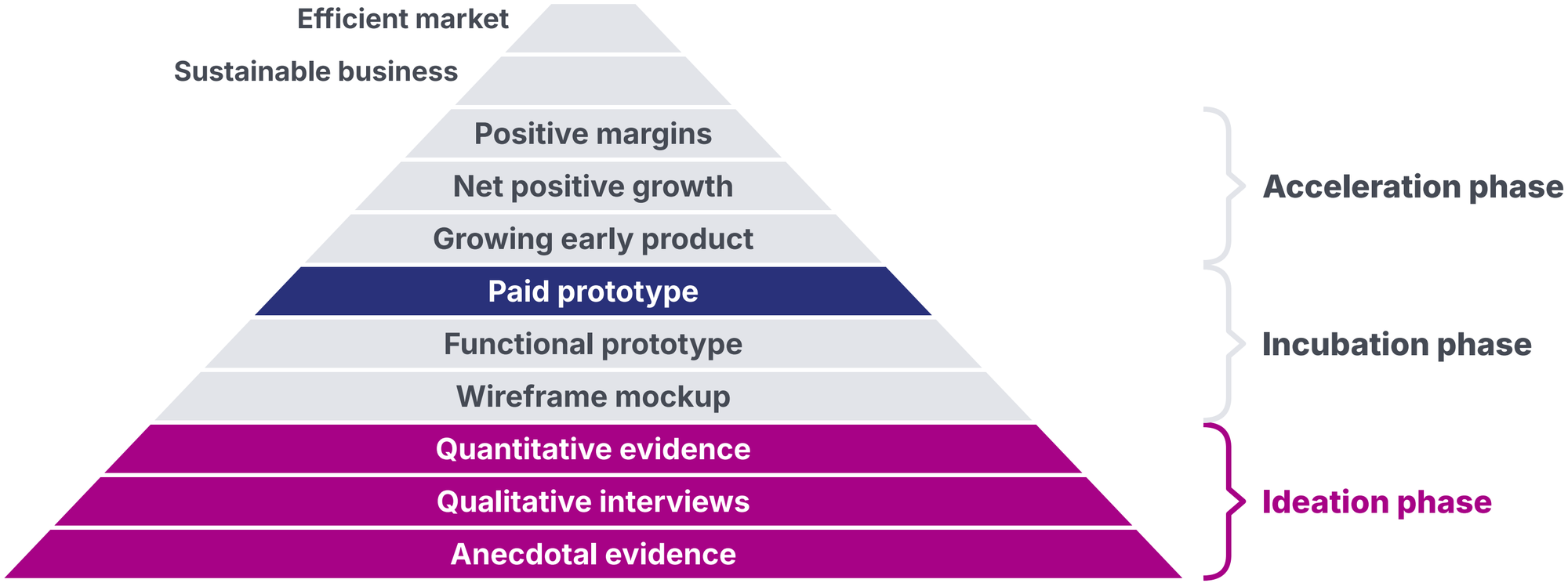


Everybody has a 24-step plan until reality punches them in the face.

After Mike Tyson

CORNERSTONE · HIERARCHY OF EVIDENCE

It's a signal until somebody pays



HANDS UP · 1 MINUTE

What backs your idea today?

Rate the belief you wrote on the tier list

1. My opinion
2. An anecdote
3. A conversation
4. A payment

1:00

SPEED MATTERS

Speed matters:

Ship weekly

SPEED MATTERS

Every week, you can talk to at least

15 relevant users

15 a week is 3 a day.

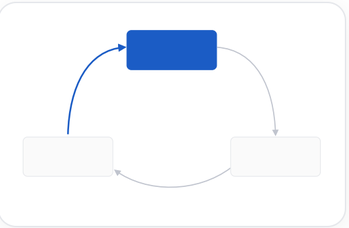
The full bar until Team (M01).

BASTIAN Number from the Kickoff (M00) homework.

SPEED MATTERS

One step should not take more than

4 hours



NOW YOU · ALONE · 2 MINUTES

What's your fastest test on a real person?

! FROM TODAY

Before you build anything

The smallest thing that reaches a real person by Friday.

→ Who exactly? A name, not a segment
→ What do you ask or show them?
→ Which day do you do it?
→ Like: "Call three HR managers from my old company on Thursday"

Output One test, one name, one day

Minutes 2

2:00

INPUT 3 OF 3 · TEST IT · THE ANSWERS

Test it: one loop a week

1

How can a small team beat a big one?

By learning faster. While BMW runs one loop, you can run twenty

2

What is your idea, really?

A hypothesis a stranger could prove wrong, and a signal until somebody pays

3

How fast should you test?

Ship weekly, talk to 15 users a week, no step over 4 hours

CHAPTER 4 OF 6

How this course works

Thirteen weeks built for speed, ending with a team, a validated idea and first revenue.

01 ~~Aim it: why now, and why you~~

02 ~~Ground it: start from a problem~~

03 ~~Test it: one loop a week~~

04 **How this course works**

05 Wrap-up and check-out

06 Workshop: autopsy your startup before it dies

COURSE PATH

Thirteen weeks from first leads to first euros

The best teams make more than **€10,000** in revenue along the way

00 **Kickoff**
your first sales leads

01 **Team & foundations**
one shared problem space

02 **Finding ideas**
the first names on your prospect list

03 **The problem space**
your first prospects

04 **Validating problems**
your first testers and buyers

05 **The solution space**
MVP spec + deployed Weekend Build

06 **Prototyping with AI**
deployed prototype + 10 non-friend reactions

07 **The kill decision**
provisional verdict

08 **Finding first users**
first revenue from strangers

09 **Prototype to product**
more revenue

10 **Product management**
more revenue

11 **Founder health**
more revenue

12 **Fundraising & demo day**
verified revenue

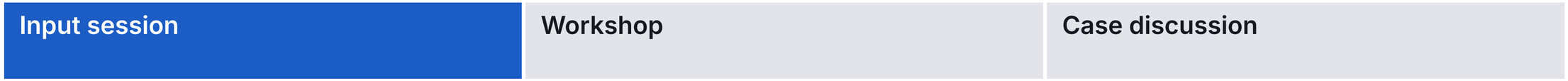
BASTIAN Week's goals of the module READMEs, 00 to 04 confirmed 2026-10-19. 05 to 07 the current weekly bars, from 08 on revenue without fixed amounts. The €10,000 line is Bastian's (2026-10-19).

HOW A WEEK RUNS

Every module offers three blocks

Each block works on its own

About 90 minutes each · drawn to scale



BLOCK	WHAT HAPPENS
Input session	Check-in, recap, your read-out, new content, wrap-up
Workshop	You start the week's work on your own venture
Case discussion	A real founder's decision, prepared at home in 4 to 6 hours

FROM TEAM (M01) ON · EVERY WEEK

3:00

Show us where you're at in 3 minutes or less!

Start with your target against your actual

Facts

Statistics or research

What do they say?

What does it mean?

Where are they from?

Numbers

Usage or surveys

How were they reported?

How did they change?

Why is it relevant?

Quotes

Interviews or testimonials

What did they say?

Why did they say it?

What could this mean?

Images

Screenshots or users

What happened?

What changed?

Why is it relevant?

What did you do?

What did you learn?

How can we help?

EVERY WEEK

Every week, your target against your actual

1

User interactions?

What did you learn?

2

New revenue?

Why did they pay, or not?

3

What did you ship?

Why does it matter to them?

🦄 **Report target vs. actual. Say candidly why you hit it or missed it**

THE TRAP

Busy feels like progress. Mostly it isn't

Five full days. Which one would a customer notice?

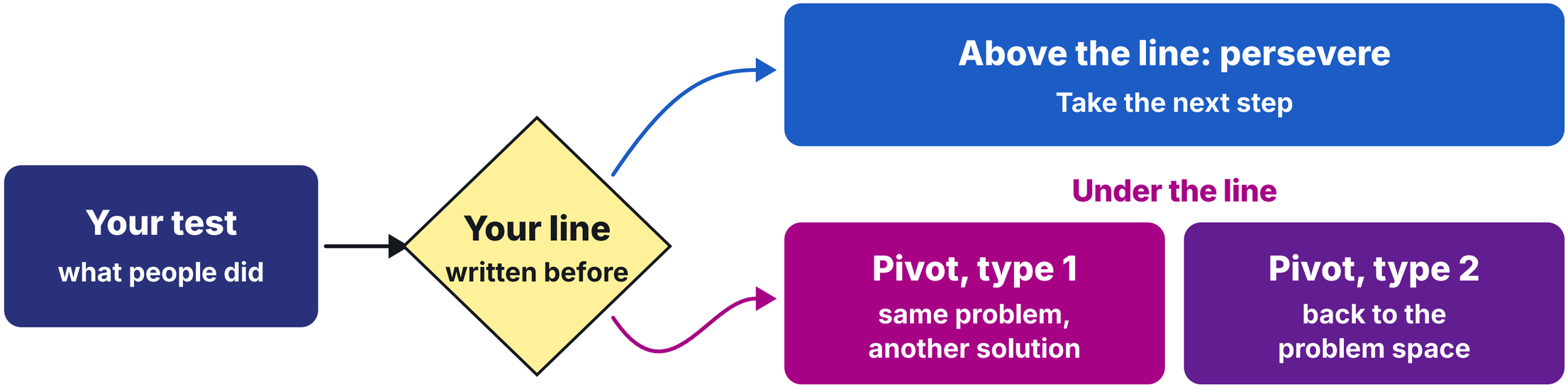
	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI
	New logo	Grant form	Pitch deck version 5	Competitor list	Call 5 customers
Felt busy	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
A customer noticed	✗	✗	✗	✗	✓

YC "It's very easy to feel busy and feel productive and not be moving your business forward." Divya Bhat, YC Startup School. The week is made up.

PIVOT OR PERSEVERE

Under your line? That is a decision, not a failure

From today, every test ends in one of two moves, and both are progress



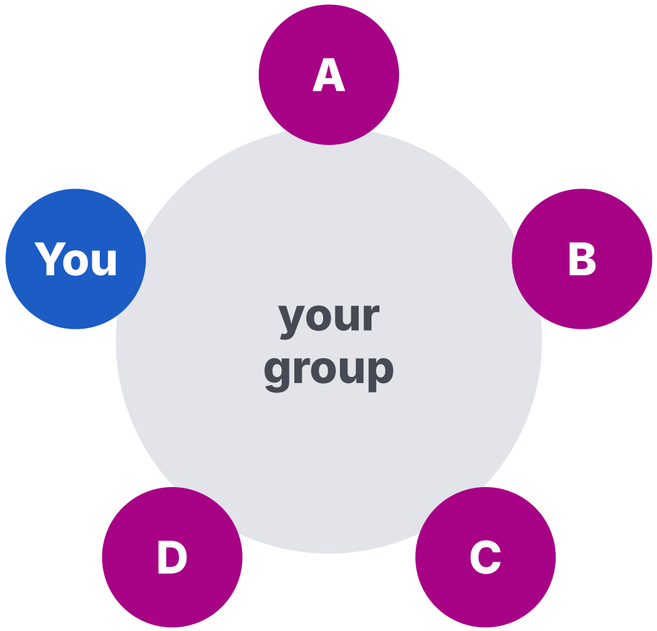
Both are progress. The only miss: no line, so no decision

FRAMEWORK Pivot or persevere after Ries, E. (2011), The Lean Startup. Pivot types as in the course Glossary.

THE GROUP

Three to seven teams. Every two weeks. One goal each

Informal, short and candid. No slides, numbers first



3–7 teams at your pace

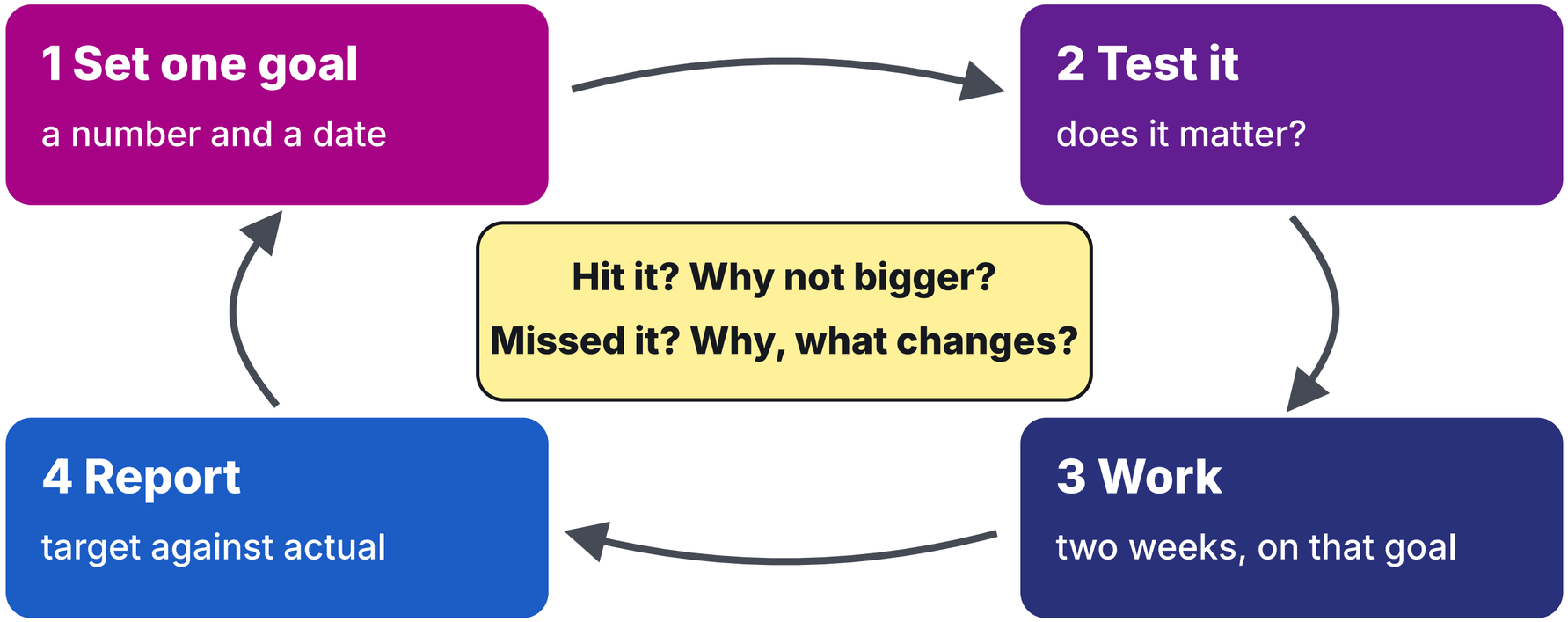
2 weeks between meetings

45 minutes at most

1 goal per team

THE TWO-WEEK CYCLE

Set it, test it, do it, then answer for it



THE GOAL TEST

Test every goal before you work on it

Two no's, and the team rewrites it before the meeting ends

Learning?
Will we know something about customers that we don't know today?

Revenue?
Does it bring a paying customer closer?

Lasting?
Does it build a business that can carry itself?

WEAK

"Apply for EXIST"

GOOD

"3 of our 10 hottest prospects pay for a pilot in two weeks"

BASTIAN Bastian's three questions and two-no rule (2026-10-20). Example goals are illustrative.

THE CANDID RULE

Hit every goal? Then they were too small

Average share of target over several cycles, to scale. Zones are a rule of thumb



"... when you are your own boss, you are screwing yourself." Michael Seibel on sandbagging

YC Seibel and Caldwell, YC, Setting smarter goals. The sweet spot is Google's rule of thumb for stretch goals (re:Work), not a research finding. Zone limits from the course's group tracker.

Y COMBINATOR DOES IT

YC asks every batch the same question

Group office hours every two weeks, 6 to 10 companies

> **"... what were your goals for the last two weeks and did you hit the goals? And if you didn't hit them, what came in the way of hitting the goals?"**
>
> Gustaf Alströmer, YC group partner, 2023

2 weeks
between group office hours

6 to 10
companies per section

years
many groups go on after YC

YC Alströmer, G. (2023, March 2). Lessons from working with 600+ YC startups. Lenny's Podcast, transcript copy. Y Combinator, About page, two page copies.

THE TOOL

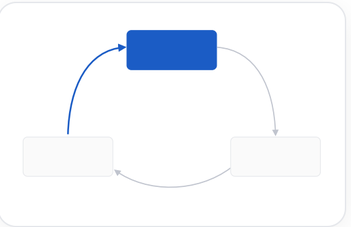
Run the group from one spreadsheet

Left half when you set the goal, right half two weeks later

Team	Two-week goal (one sentence, with a number and a date)	Target	Learning?	Revenue?	Lasting?	Group: ambition	Actual	Share of target	Result
Team Kiln	Get 3 of our 10 hottest prospects to pay for a two-week pilot in two weeks	3	Yes	Yes	Yes	Right	3	100%	Hit
Team Rota	Hold 30 problem conversations with care-home shift leads, 10 next steps, in two weeks	10	Yes	Yes	No	Right	6	60%	Missed
Team Receipt	Apply for EXIST	1	No	No	No	Too small			

> The sheet flags a goal that fails the test, and the scoreboard says when to raise the bar

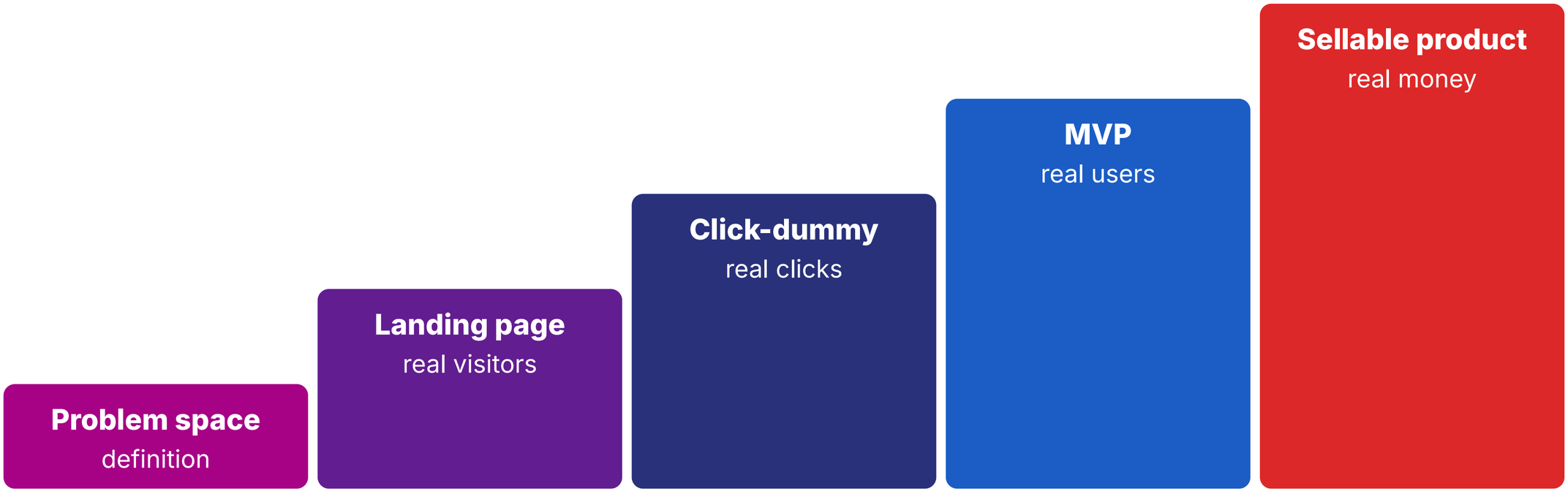
ILLUSTRATIVE Accountability Group Tracker in the course resources, screenshot 2026-10-20. Teams and goals are made up.



THE WORKSHOP LADDER

Your work climbs five rungs toward real users

Your results are for users to interact with



HOW YOU'RE GRADED

Evidence and decisions weigh as much as revenue

You're not graded on sticking to your idea

The rubric · drawn to scale

Evidence quality	Decision discipline	Verified traction	Commu-nication
30%	30%	30%	10%

A well-argued kill with a documented evidence pack can earn an A.

A VERY GOOD RESULT IS A GROWING STARTUP

Work on what you control

Things you can control

- 😍 Talk to 15 users each week
- 📈 Present your progress every week and ask for help
- 🎁 Offer critical feedback and questions
- 🔬 Be an expert in your problem space
- 🔄 Pivot when you hit a brick wall

Things you can't totally control

- 🖥️ Steady growth on your landing page
- 📇 A lead list of potential users
- 🤑 Paying customers

HOW WE WORK TOGETHER

Be present or be elsewhere

1

Together we grow: coachability

We give candid and productive feedback. We listen and seek to understand.

2

We act as we say: accountability

We stick to our word where it's in our hands. We learn from failures where it's not.

3

Give first, dream first: bias to action

We prefer building and experimenting over understanding every aspect.

DOS AND DON'TS IN THIS SEMINAR

Pivoting is fine. A knowingly bad idea isn't

Totally fine

- 🦄 Building wild ideas
- 😵‍💫 Regrouping
- 😉 Pivoting
- 😵 Failing

Not OK in here

- 👻 Sticking with a knowingly bad idea
- ⏰ Being late
- 🛌 Missing class
- 🤐 Staying silent when you don't understand

WHAT YOU LEAVE WITH

A team, a validated idea and first revenue

The best teams make more than €10,000 along the way

Team

2 to 4 people who commit to each other

Idea

validated: somebody paid for it

€

first revenue in the bank

BASTIAN Bastian's course goal (2026-10-19). "Validated" as in the course glossary (GLOSSARY.md): somebody opens their wallet.

WHAT WE ARE WORKING TOWARDS · THE SEQUOIA PITCH

Every phase earns part of your pitch

1	Company purpose	COVER
2	Problem	PROBLEM
3	Solution	SOLUTION
4	Why now?	PROBLEM
5	Market potential	COVER
6	Competition	PROBLEM
7	Business model	SOLUTION
8	Team	COVER
9	Financials	
10	Vision	
11	Roadmap	COVER

FRAMEWORK Sequoia Capital (2019), Writing a business plan, ten sections. Course material, plus Bastian's roadmap.

TEAMS FORM BY TEAM (M01)

Find teammates now, or we match you

4a

Find teammates

Say your problem space in one sentence

Talk to the people who share it, from today

4b

We match you

Nobody found by Team (M01)?

We match you on your problem space

CHAPTER 5 OF 6

Wrap-up and check-out

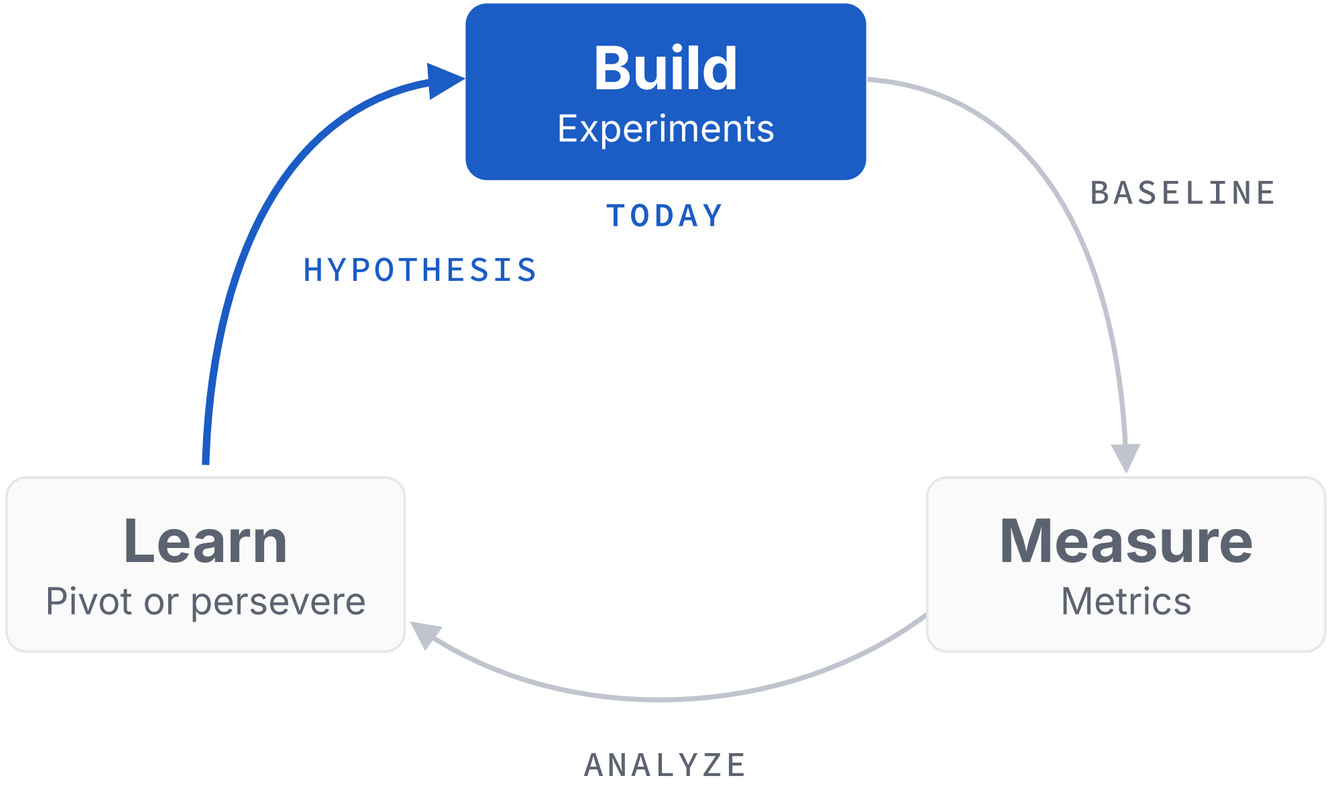
What you take home today, and the fifteen conversations that start today.

01 ~~Aim it: why now, and why you~~
02 ~~Ground it: start from a problem~~
03 ~~Test it: one loop a week~~
04 ~~How this course works~~
05 **Wrap-up and check-out**
06 Workshop: autopsy your startup before it dies

RECAP · CORNERSTONE

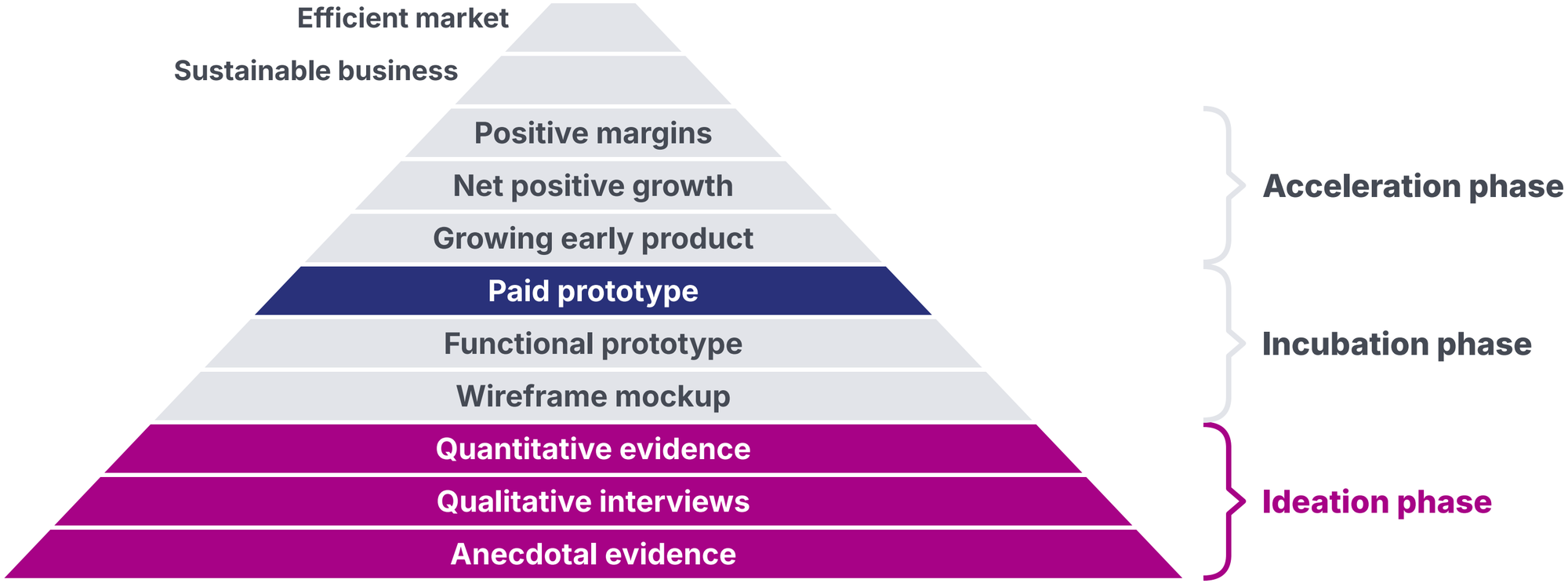
One full turn by next time, not this semester

You started today. Close it by Team (M01)



RECAP · CORNERSTONE

Climb from opinions to a payment



REFLECTION 1 OF 3 · THE CONTENT

What could you apply?



What could you apply?



What gave you a hard time?

REFLECTION 2 OF 3 · THE PROCESS

Man vs. machine



Where did AI actually help you?



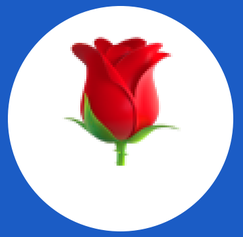
Where was your genius needed?



What are your best hacks to share?

REFLECTION 3 OF 3 · THE RESULTS

Rose, thorn, bud



What was the breakthrough today?



What was the hardest part today?



What is an idea/feature you didn't have time to finish, but want to explore later?

HOMEWORK UNTIL TEAM (M01)

Write 3 problem hypotheses and hold 15 problem conversations with named people, learning what the problem costs each of them today, and come back with 3 people who agreed to a next step.

15 conversations

The learning floor is 3 hypotheses and 5 conversations with 1 next step.

Log your kill line before your first conversation.

HOMEWORK · HOW TO

Find your people where they already are

Fifteen conversations means three a day. Start today

1

People you see every day

Colleagues, clients, your lab. What do they complain about, and whom do they know?

2

Be a fly on the wall

Sit in on a shift or a support queue. Note what people curse at

3

Read bad reviews

1 to 3 stars on Trustpilot, G2 or Capterra. Repeated complaints are problems

4

AI deep research

Ask where your "who" complains online

HOMEWORK · WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE

Dig deeper, or move on

A narrow, deep well: a few people want it fixed badly. A made-up example

	DIG DEEPER	MOVE ON
Who	Lab managers in biotech start-ups	"Researchers"
Raised	4 of 10, before I named it	Only once I named it
Cost	4 hours a week, 2 built Excel trackers	"Annoying, but we live with it"
How many	6 of 10, in 4 labs	Me and my flatmate

ILLUSTRATIVE Kickoff (M00) homework, "What you come back with", made-up example. "Narrow, deep well" after Graham (2012).

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See you in Team (M01), with names and numbers!

MODULE 00 · WORKSHOP · 90 MINUTES

Workshop: Autopsy your startup before it dies

Find what could kill your idea, write hypotheses you can lose, and reach real people today.

What kills startups, and what will this course demand from you?

01 ~~Aim it: why now, and why you~~
02 ~~Ground it: start from a problem~~
03 ~~Test it: one loop a week~~
04 ~~How this course works~~
05 ~~Wrap-up and check-out~~
06 **Workshop: autopsy your startup before it dies**

WORKSHOP · STEP 1 OF 3

Autopsy your own startup

1 STEP 1 · 25 MIN

AUTOPSY YOUR OWN STARTUP

Find the customer assumption that kills your idea

→ Your starting point in one line
→ One year on, your startup is dead. Why?
→ Each cause becomes "We assumed ..."
→ Circle the riskiest untested one
→ Pairs: "How do you know?"

Output Riskiest untested assumption, in the Weekly Reflection

Minutes 25

25:00

WORKSHOP · STEP 2 OF 3

Write hypotheses you can lose

2 STEP 2 · 25 MIN

WRITE HYPOTHESES YOU CAN LOSE

Hypotheses a stranger could prove wrong this week

→ 3 hypotheses: who, problem, situation, workaround, cost
→ Rate the evidence: opinion, anecdote, conversation, payment
→ Rank them, riskiest first, start AI deep research
→ Kill line logged before any contact

Output 3 ranked hypotheses, their evidence, a kill line

Minutes 25

25:00

WORKSHOP · STEP 3 OF 3

Reach real people, then commit

3 STEP 3 · 40 MIN

REACH REAL PEOPLE, THEN COMMIT

Leave with the week already moving

→ 10 min: pick named people from your research
→ 15 min: 5 messages to named people, or one call
→ Don't name your problem, do NOT pitch
→ 10 min: floor or full bar, midweek pace
→ 5 min: your problem space in one sentence, find teammates

Output Messages sent, target, pace, possible teammates

Minutes 40

40:00

ARRIVED EMPTY-HANDED?

No idea yet? Run the autopsy on a frustration you watched someone fight last month.

1 real frustration

HOMEWORK UNTIL TEAM (M01)

Write 3 problem hypotheses and hold 15 problem conversations with named people, learning what the problem costs each of them today, and come back with 3 people who agreed to a next step.

15 conversations

The learning floor is 3 hypotheses and 5 conversations with 1 next step.

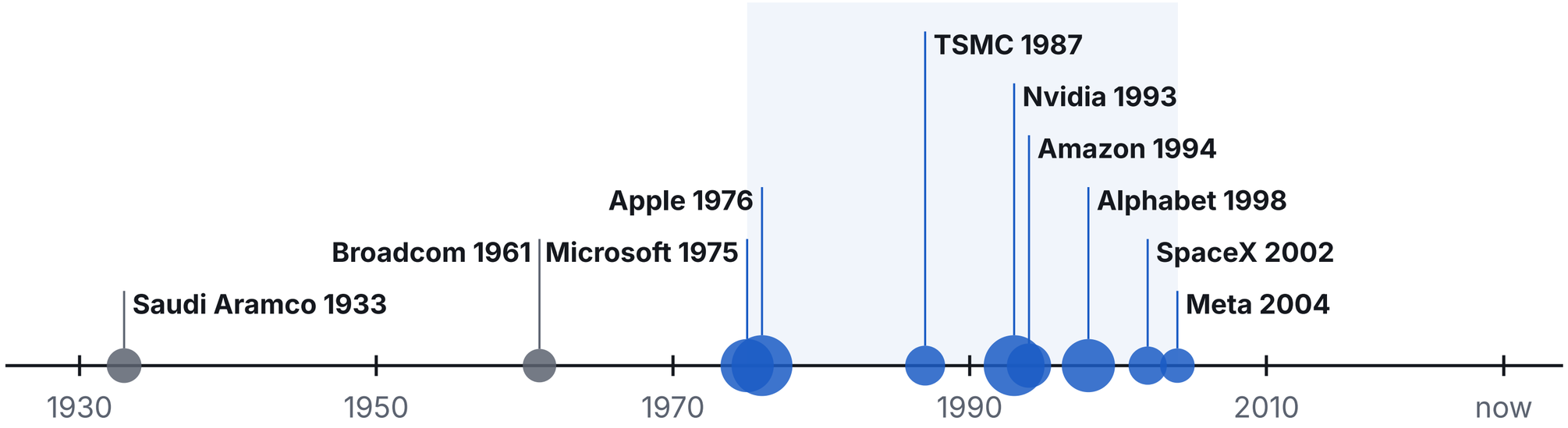
Log your kill line before your first conversation.

See you in Team (M01), with names and numbers!

BACKUP · EVIDENCE FOR SLIDES 3 AND 4

Today's giants were born in the last tech transitions

The ten most valuable companies on 26 October 2026, by founding year. Dot area shows market value

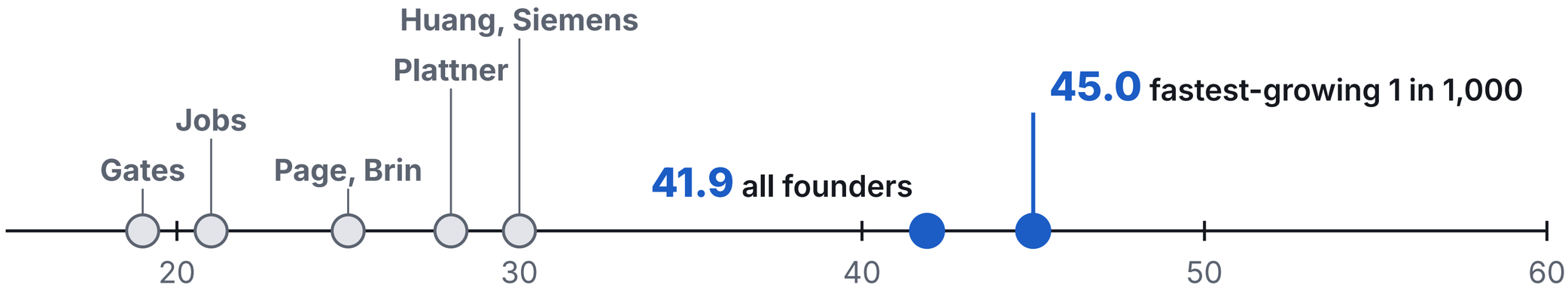


DATA CompaniesMarketCap, market values of 26 October 2026. Founding years from Wikipedia, retrieved 2026-10-26. Draghi, M. (2024). The future of European competitiveness. European Commission.

BACKUP · EVIDENCE FOR SLIDE 8

Top-growth founders are 45 and know their field

Mean age at founding, 2.7 million US founders of new employer firms, 2007 to 2014



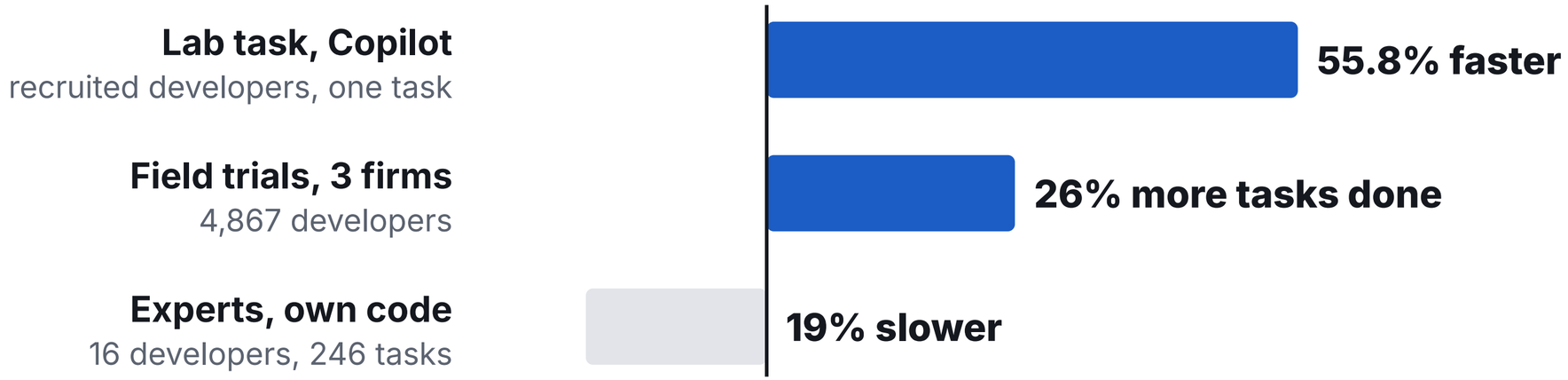
EXPERIENCE **Three or more years in the industry doubles the odds of top growth, 0.22% against 0.11%.**

RESEARCH Azoulay, P., Jones, B. F., Kim, J. D., & Miranda, J. (2020). Age and high-growth entrepreneurship. *American Economic Review: Insights*, 2(1), 65–82.

BACKUP · EVIDENCE FOR SLIDE 9

AI speeds up building, but not for every expert

Three studies with five randomized trials, three different measures

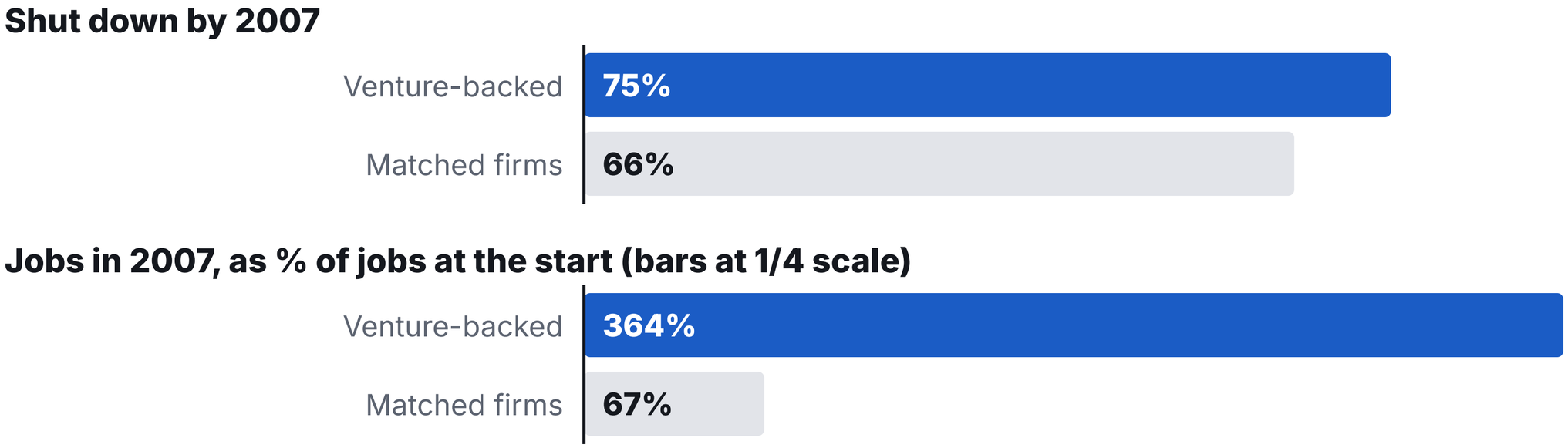


RESEARCH Peng et al. (2023), arXiv preprint 2302.06590. Cui et al. (2026), Management Science. Becker, Rush, Barnes & Rein (2025), arXiv preprint 2507.09089.

BACKUP · EVIDENCE FOR SLIDE 11

Big bets fail a bit more often, and grow far bigger

US firms that raised venture capital in 1986 to 1997, against matched firms of the same industry, year and size

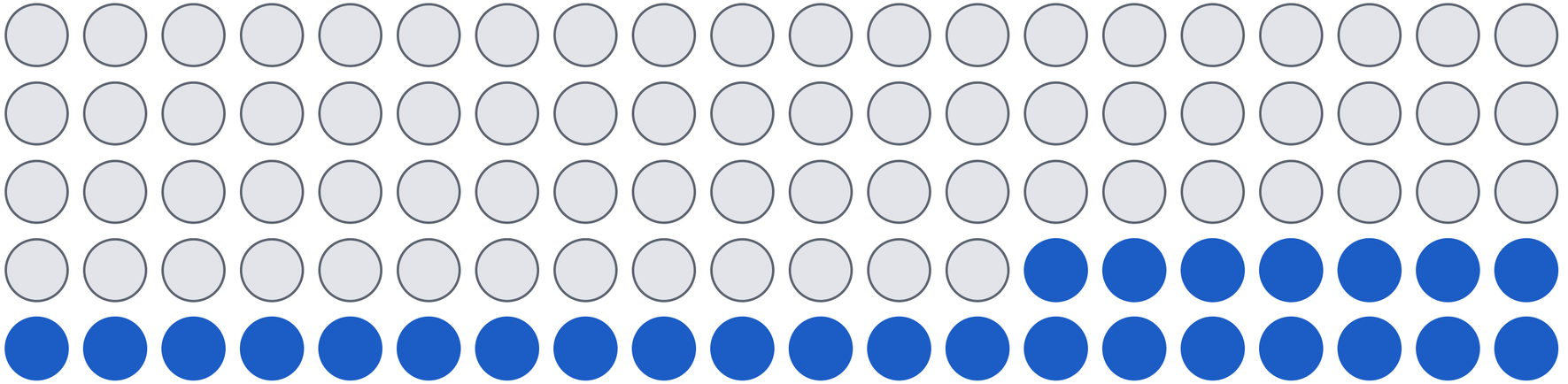


RESEARCH Kerr, W. R., Nanda, R., & Rhodes-Kropf, M. (2014). Entrepreneurship as experimentation. *Journal of Economic Perspectives*, 28(3), Figure 3. US Census data.

BACKUP · EVIDENCE FOR SLIDE 11

Ambition raises the ceiling, not the typical payoff

Venture-backed US founders since 1987, cash each founder took at exit



73 of 100 get nothing at exit

27 get some cash

$5.8m
average exit cash, a few over $1 billion

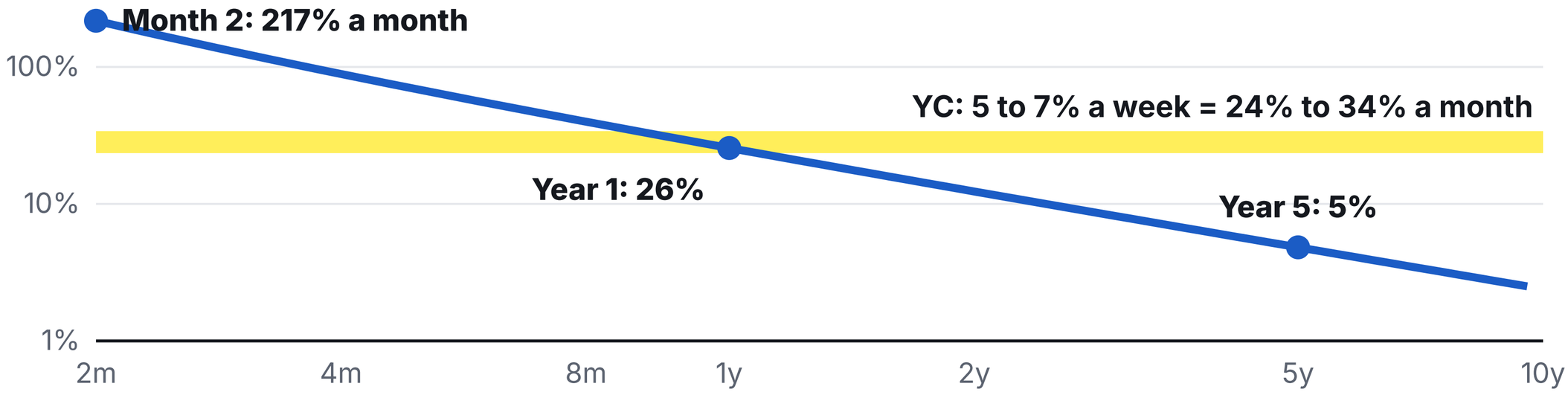
Barely
more than a job, valued at launch by a founder who dislikes risk

RESEARCH Hall, R. E., & Woodward, S. E. (2010). The burden of the nondiversifiable risk of entrepreneurship. *American Economic Review*, 100(3), 1163–1194.

BACKUP · THE MATHS OF SLIDE 14

The line multiplies revenue 7× each time your age doubles

Monthly growth falls as you grow and meets YC's yardstick near year one

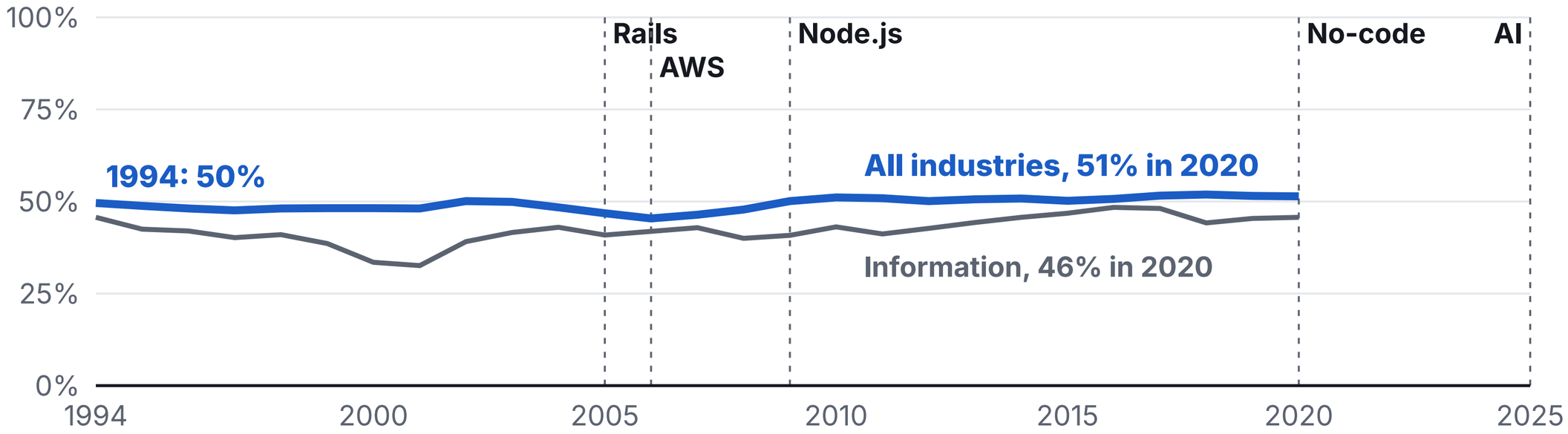


ILLUSTRATIVE Read off the line on slide 14, which is not a scientific chart. Revenue grows with age to the power 2.85. Yardstick from Graham, P. (2012), Startup = growth.

BACKUP · EVIDENCE FOR SLIDES 15 AND 25

Building got cheaper. Survival stayed near one in two

New US establishments still open five years later, by year opened, 1994 to 2020



DATA U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Business Employment Dynamics, Table 7, all private industries and Information (NAICS 51), data to March 2025.

BACKUP · EVIDENCE FOR SLIDE 21

Grant money buys time. The jury's label proves nothing

EU SME Instrument 2014 to 2017, firms just above against just below the funding line. Employment effect

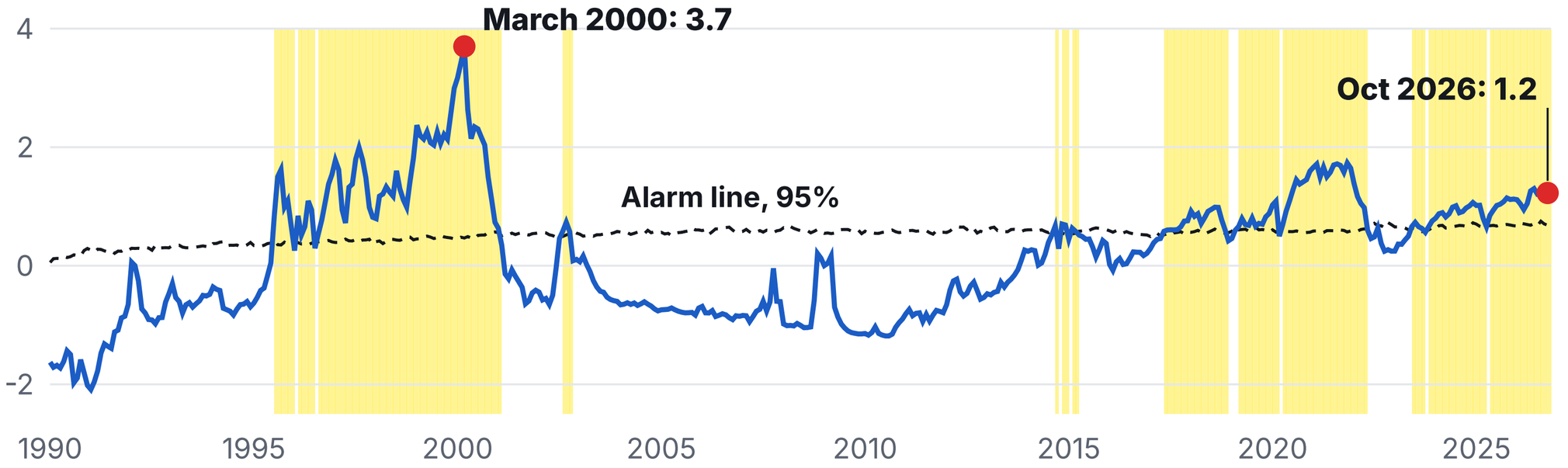


RESEARCH Santoleri, P., Mina, A., Di Minin, A., & Martelli, I. (2024). The causal effects of R&D grants: Evidence from a regression discontinuity. *Review of Economics and Statistics*, 106(6).

BACKUP · EVIDENCE FOR SLIDES 26 AND 27

The bubble alarm rings, but far quieter than in 2000

Explosive-price test on the Nasdaq-100, monthly, after inflation. Shaded months sit above the alarm line

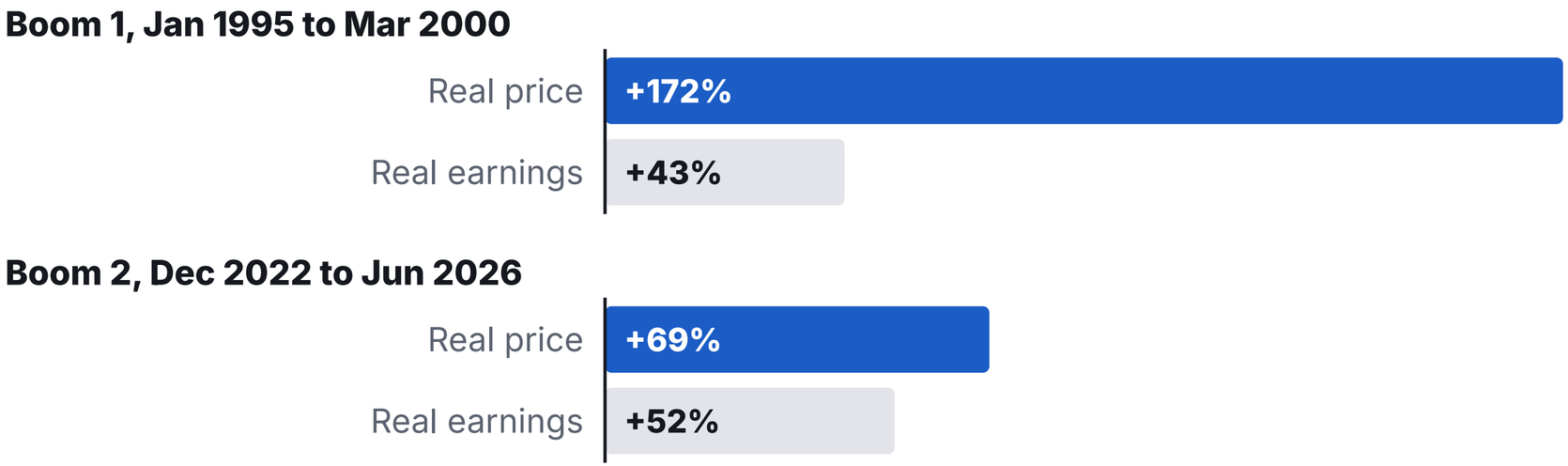


DATA Own calculation for this course, test after Phillips, Shi & Yu (2015), 2,000 simulations. Nasdaq-100 and consumer prices from FRED (2026).

BACKUP · EVIDENCE FOR SLIDES 26 AND 27

1999-high valuations, but profits mostly kept up

S&P 500 after inflation, change in price and in earnings during two tech booms.
Bars to scale



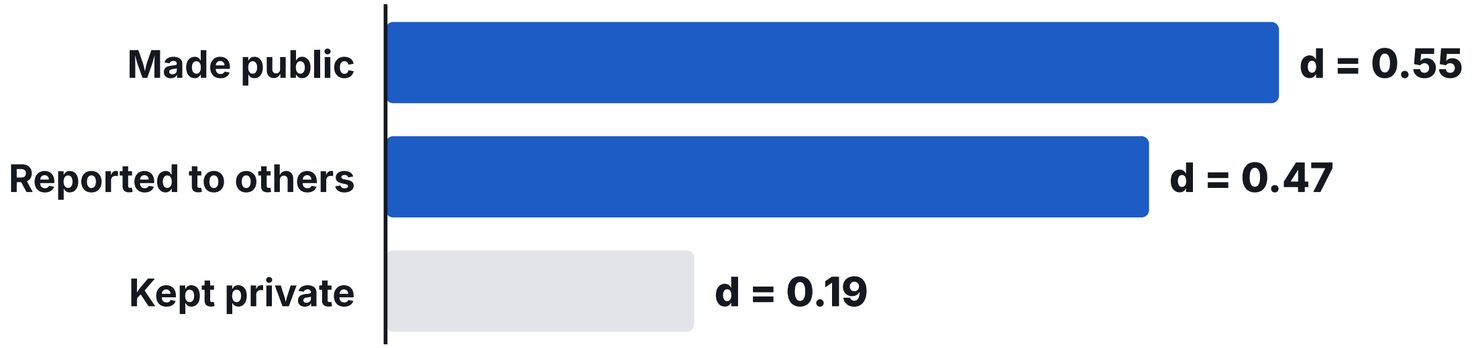
AND YET **CAPE was 40.7 in October 2026. Only 1999, 2000 and 2026 ever reached it.**

DATA Shiller, R. J. (2026). U.S. stock markets 1871 to present and CAPE ratio [Data set]. Own calculation for this course.

BACKUP · EVIDENCE FOR SLIDES 50 TO 54

Goals are reached more often when progress is reported

Monitoring progress toward a goal, effect on reaching it, 138 randomized studies



PEER GROUPS **Monthly meetings of 10 managers raised their firms' revenue by 8.1% (2,800 firms, randomized).**

RESEARCH Harkin, B., et al. (2016). Does monitoring goal progress promote goal attainment? *Psychological Bulletin*, 142(2). Cai, J., & Szeidl, A. (2018). Interfirm relationships and business performance. *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 133(3).

Sources of the backup slides

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